over. I hit the first ball for six over long on and followed it up with a four off the third ball. The fourth ball resulted in a second six, which I hit straight over the bowler's head. Seeing me hit straight, Qadir bowled the fifth ball wide outside off stump in an attempt to get me stumped. I had anticipated the move and hit the ball over long off for the third six of the over. For the last ball he went even further outside off stump and I stretched out to hit the ball wide over long off, to make it four sixes in the over.

The crowd, which had been confident of a Pakistan victory till an over earlier, was roused by this unexpected turn of events and started making a lot of noise. There was a sudden increase in energy levels at the ground. The match was now being played in full seriousness and no one really knew which team would win. We needed 14 runs off the last over, bowled by Wasim Akram. Eventually we fell short by three runs. Straight after the match, Abdul Qadir walked up to me in true sportsmanlike manner and said '*Bahut ala batting.*' (Very well batted.)

That innings of 53 off eighteen balls at Peshawar had a defining impact on my career. In the eyes of the public, it had overshadowed my effort at Sialkot, which was far more difficult and far more significant as far as I was concerned. The Sialkot innings had allowed us to save the Test match and also the series. But for people at home the innings at Peshawar was the real talking point. It had given me instant recognition and made me a household name. For the first time I was asked for autographs, which was a strange feeling. Before we went to Pakistan I had been able to go out with my friends and have *bhel* (a type of fast food loved all over Mumbai) and do all those normal things. Afterwards, when I went out with my friends, people would come up and ask if I was Sachin Tendulkar. And it was all down to that one innings at Peshawar. While it would have been premature to suggest I had established myself at international level, it had certainly given me a toehold.

When I got home, I could tell that my parents were proud of my achievements, but there has never been any over-the-top celebration in my house. While I knew that my father was extremely happy and satisfied, he wouldn't ever show off his emotions in an extravagant manner. When I did well, my mother would always light a *diya* (a kind of candle) and offer sweets to God, but that's as far as it went. Sometimes people are kind enough to compliment me on my off-the-field behaviour more than my on-field performance. They say that I seem